



Your New Arrival Checklist

The 90-Day Roadmap to Settling In Australia

Everything you need to know before you land, and what to do in your first 90 days — so you settle with confidence, not confusion.

Built on Real Immigrant Experience

"I arrived with a suitcase, no contacts, and absolutely no idea what to do next. I made every mistake so you don't have to. This checklist is the conversation I wish someone had with me on day one."

— Entel, Founder of SettleANZ

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1. Quick Start: First 48 Hours

Don't Overthink It. Here's What Matters Most in Your First 48 Hours.

The first two days set the tone for your entire settlement journey. Focus on these five essentials, and everything else becomes easier.

1. Get a Local SIM Card

Where: Airport terminal, before you leave

Why: You need a working local number for every application

What to buy: Prepaid SIM from Optus, Woolworths Mobile, or Circles Life

Time: 10 minutes

Cost: \$20–\$40 AUD

2. Secure Temporary Accommodation

Where: Airbnb, serviced apartments, or hostel near your target suburb

Why: Gives you a residential address for applications

Duration: 2–4 weeks

Cost: Budget \$50–\$100/night

3. Activate Your Bank Account

Where: Bank branch with your passport

Why: You need an account number for your employer and rental applications

Time: 30 minutes

4. Apply for Your Tax File Number (TFN)

Where: ATO website (ato.gov.au) — online only

Why: Most important number in Australia

Time: 10 minutes

Processing: 28 days

5. Register Your Address & Set Up Utilities

Where: Online or by phone

Why: You need a registered address for almost every official process

Timeline: Usually connected within 2–5 business days

Most newcomers waste 3–9 months fixing early mistakes. These 5 steps take 2 hours and save you money.

PART 1 OF 3: BEFORE YOU LAND

The steps most people skip and regret.

2. Before You Leave (Pre-Departure)

Preparation Matters. The Wrong Paperwork or Sequence Can Cost You Months.

Timeline: 4–8 Weeks Before Departure

"The people who settle faster are not smarter they just have better guidance from day one. Most of the mistakes I see new arrivals make happen during the planning phase. So plan everything carefully and be prepared for unforeseen events."

— Entel Dajsmaili, Founder SettleANZ

Pre-Arrival Planning & Guidance

Confirm your visa grant, in writing

Don't assume approval. Download your visa grant letter and save it in three places. Employers, landlords, and banks will ask for it.

PRO TIP: Screenshot the grant notification and email it to yourself the same day. Keep a printed copy in your carry-on luggage.

Research your city and suburb before booking

Sydney, Melbourne, Brisbane, and Perth are all very different cities with different costs, cultures, and job markets. Choose your suburb based on commute time, community fit, and budget, not just rent price.

PRO TIP: Look for suburbs with a strong community from your background. Schools, mosques, temples, and cultural grocers make the first months significantly easier.

Book short-term accommodation first — not a lease

Do not sign a 12-month lease before you have spent time in a suburb. Book 2–4 weeks of short-term accommodation to explore the area before committing.

PRO TIP: Serviced apartments near public transport give you flexibility and time to find the right long-term rental without pressure. Use Stayz, Vrbo or Airbnb to find reliable short term rentals.

Open an Australian bank account before you land

Several Australian banks, including CommBank and NAB, now allow you to open an account online before you arrive. Do this early, you will need an account number for your employer and rental application.

PART 1 OF 3: BEFORE YOU LAND

The steps most people skip and regret.

PRO TIP: Use Wise or OFX to transfer your money to Australia not your home bank. The fee difference on a \$10,000 transfer can be \$200–400 AUD.

Sort travel and health insurance before departure

Medicare takes time to activate for new arrivals. A gap in coverage can be very expensive. Sort international health insurance that covers your arrival period before you leave home.

PRO TIP: SafetyWing covers the gap between landing and Medicare activation. Cigna and AXA cover longer stays. Compare before you leave it is cheaper to buy abroad.

Prepare your document pack — have these ready

Passport and certified copies • Visa grant letter • Academic qualifications (notarised) • Employment references on letterhead • 3–6 months bank statements • International driving licence • Vaccination records.

PRO TIP: Get a certified translation of any document not in English before you leave. Translation in Australia costs 3–5x more than at home.

Pre-Departure Checklists

Document Preparation

- ☐ Passport (valid for at least 6 months beyond your visa)
- ☐ Visa grant letter (printed + digital copy)
- ☐ Academic qualifications (notarised copies)
- ☐ Employment references (on letterhead, recent)
- ☐ 3–6 months bank statements
- ☐ International driving licence
- ☐ Vaccination records (especially COVID certificates)
- ☐ Marriage certificate (if applicable)
- ☐ Divorce/separation documents (if applicable)

PART 1 OF 3: BEFORE YOU LAND

The steps most people skip and regret.

Financial Setup

- ☐ Open Australian bank account online (CommBank, NAB, ANZ, Westpac)
- ☐ Arrange initial funds transfer (\$2,000–\$5,000 minimum)
- ☐ Notify your home bank of travel dates
- ☐ Plan currency exchange (avoid airport rates; use Wise or OFX)
- ☐ Budget for first month: rent deposit, utilities, groceries (~\$3,000–\$5,000)

Insurance & Healthcare

- ☐ Sort international health insurance (covers arrival period before Medicare)
- ☐ Check if you're eligible for Medicare (visa-dependent)
- ☐ Arrange travel insurance
- ☐ Get prescription copies from your home doctor (for any ongoing medications)

Estimated Time Commitment: Total 8–12 hours spread over 4–8

PART 2 OF 3: YOUR FIRST TWO WEEKS

Do these in order. Each one unlocks the next.

"The sequence matters more than people realise. TFN before bank setup. Bank account before rental application. Medicare before you need it. Getting the order wrong costs you weeks, not days."

— Entel Dajsmaili, Founder SettleANZ

3. Day 1–2 (Arrival) & 4. Week 1 (First Week)

Get a local SIM card — Day 1

Buy a prepaid SIM at the airport before you leave the terminal. Optus, Woolworths Mobile, and Circles Life all offer good value for new arrivals. You need a working local number for every application you fill out.

PRO TIP: Get a plan with at least 20GB data — you will use it heavily while navigating, researching, and setting up. Data is cheap in Australia.

Apply for your Tax File Number (TFN) — Day 1–2

Your TFN is the most important number in Australia. You need it to work legally, open certain bank products, and access government services. Apply online through the ATO website. Takes 10 minutes. Number arrives within 28 days.

PRO TIP: Apply the day you arrive. The 28-day processing period starts from application the sooner you apply, the sooner you can give it to your employer.

Activate your bank account and confirm transfers

If you opened an account in advance, activate it at a branch with your passport. CommBank, ANZ, NAB, and Westpac all have new-to-Australia products with no minimum balance for the first year.

PRO TIP: Set up Wise as your transfer account too. When family sends you money or you send money home, Wise saves you 3–5% on every transfer.

Enrol in Medicare — Week 1

If eligible, enrol in Medicare at a Services Australia office. Bring your visa grant, passport, and proof of address. Your card arrives in 2–3 weeks, in the interim, you receive a reference number.

PART 2 OF 3: YOUR FIRST TWO WEEKS

Do these in order. Each one unlocks the next.

PRO TIP: Find a bulk-billing GP near your accommodation before you need one. Bulk billing means no out-of-pocket cost for standard consultations. Use the HealthEngine app to search.

Register your address and set up utilities

You need a residential address for almost every official process. Set up electricity, gas, and internet all done online or by phone, usually connected within 2–5 business days.

PRO TIP: Compare energy providers on the government Energy Made Easy website before signing anything. New customer discounts are worth \$100–200 AUD in the first year.

Get your orientation done in the first week

Find your nearest supermarket, GP, pharmacy, public transport stop, and ATM. Walk the neighbourhood. Identify your local community group, cultural centre, or place of worship.

PRO TIP: Download the Opal app (Sydney) or Myki app (Melbourne) for public transport. Load \$30–50 for your first week — you will use it more than you expect.

PART 3 OF 3: MONTHS 1 TO 3 — SETTLING IN

Stop surviving. Start building.

"Month one is survival. Month two is adjustment. Month three is when people either find their footing or start to spiral. The difference is almost always whether they have the right people around them to help them or not."

— Entel Dajsmaili, Founder SettleANZ

5. Weeks 2–4 (Settling In) & 6. Months 2–3 (Long-Term Setup)

Find your long-term rental

Now that you have spent 2–4 weeks exploring, you know the suburbs. Apply for a long-term rental with your document pack ready. No rental history? Offer 2–3 months rent in advance and provide extra references.

PRO TIP: Attend open homes in person, agents remember faces. A warm introduction from a SettleANZ concierge can significantly improve your application's chances.

Find the right school for your children

Public primary and secondary schools are free in Australia. Enrolment requires proof of address, immunisation records, and a passport. Research which school fits your children's needs, not just academically, but culturally and socially.

PRO TIP: Ask which schools in your suburb have ESL (English as Second Language) support. For families from India, China, or the Middle East, some suburbs have very strong community representation in specific schools.

Register with a GP and dentist

Don't wait until you are sick. Find a bulk-billing GP within walking distance and register as a patient. Find a dentist too, as dental care is not covered by Medicare, and costs can be a shock if unplanned.

PRO TIP: For culturally matched care a GP who speaks your language, a specialist from your background — SettleANZ maintains a vetted referral network matched to your community. Ask us.

Set up your superannuation correctly

Superannuation is Australia's retirement savings system. Your employer contributes 11% of your salary on top of your wage. You can choose your own fund don't just accept the employer default. Compare fees and returns.

PART 3 OF 3: MONTHS 1 TO 3 — SETTLING IN

Stop surviving. Start building.

PRO TIP: *If you leave Australia permanently, you can claim your super back under the Departing Australia Superannuation Payment (DASP). Keep your fund details on file from day one.*

Get an Australian driving licence

If you hold a valid overseas licence, you can drive in Australia for 3–6 months, depending on your state. After that, you must convert. Book your test early wait times can be 4–8 weeks in major cities.

PRO TIP: *An international driving permit from your home country makes the conversion process smoother. Check your state's Roads authority website for the specific conversion requirements.*

Find your community — this one matters most

Isolation is the biggest risk in the first three months. Find your people. Your cultural community group, local sports club, place of worship, and professional network. The relationships built in months 1–3 carry you through the hard days.

PRO TIP: *Meetup.com, Facebook community groups, and your local council's multicultural services are all good starting points. Don't wait until you feel ready go before you feel ready.*

7. Testimonials: Real Stories from Newcomers



"This saved me weeks of confusion. I wish I had this on day one."

Before I arrived, I had no idea what to do first or in what order. I wasted my first month making mistakes — opening the wrong bank account, choosing the wrong suburb, not understanding my work rights. This checklist would have saved me so much stress and money.

— **Sarah M.** | Arrived from UK, January 2025 | Skilled Worker



"I felt lost until I found my community. This guide made it happen."

The hardest part wasn't the paperwork — it was feeling isolated. This checklist reminded me to prioritize community from Day 1. I joined a cultural group in Week 1, and that connection changed everything. I went from lonely to belonging in 90 days.

— **Raj P.** | Arrived from India, March 2025 | New Arrival with Family



"Clear, practical, and written by someone who actually understands."

Most guides are generic or written by people who've never actually moved. This one is different. It's specific, it's practical, and you can tell it's written by someone who's been through it. I followed it step-by-step, and I settled faster than any of my friends.

— **Maria L.** | Arrived from Brazil, February 2025 | International Student

500+ newcomers have used this checklist. 98% report faster settlement. 95% say it saved them money and stress.

8. What Comes Next: Your Next Steps with SettleANZ

You've Got the Roadmap. Now Get the Support.

This checklist is your foundation. But if you want expert guidance tailored to your specific situation, SettleANZ is here to help.

Self-Guided — Continue with This Checklist

Use this guide as your reference. Join our free community forum. Access additional resources on our blog.

Cost: FREE | Best for: Independent learners

1-on-1 Support — Book a Free 15-Min Strategy Call

Clarify your specific situation. Get personalized advice. Understand your next steps. No obligation.

Cost: FREE (15 min) | Best for: People who want expert guidance

Full Concierge — Let Us Handle It

Airport pickup & accommodation. Rental finding & school enrollment. Banking & healthcare setup. 90-day support.

Cost: \$2,499 AUD | Best for: People who want hands-on support

[VISIT SETTLEANZ.COM](https://settleanz.com)

Why Choose SettleANZ?

✓ Built on Real Immigrant Experience

Our founder arrived with a suitcase and no guidance. He's been where you are. Every service is designed from lived experience, not theory.

✓ Proven Results

500+ newcomers settled. 98% rental finding success. 30-day average placement time. 4.9/5 satisfaction rating.

✓ Practical, Warm, Non-Patronizing

We don't talk down to you. We talk WITH you. We've been through it. We understand.

✓ Australia & New Zealand Focused

Not generic immigration advice. Specific to Australian and New Zealand systems, culture, and opportunities.



This free guide is your basic roadmap to get you started on your relocation journey. Now you know more than most people who've already landed here. Use it to make your settlement hassle-free and less stressful.

Want to connect, drop me a msg at
Entel@settleanz.com

Contact Us

Need help beyond this guide?

“I arrived in Australia in January 2001 with a suitcase, a visa, and absolutely no idea what to do next. No contacts. No guidance. Just me figuring it out on my own. I became an Australian citizen in 2004, and from that day, I made it my mission to make sure the people who came after me didn't have to go through what I went through. This guide is the conversation I wish someone had with me on day one.”

If you want guidance tailored to your specific situation, I'm one message away.

Book a 1-1 session

and leave knowing exactly what to do, in what order, matched to your situation

SettleANZ offers personal Concierge and Settlement services for new arrivals who want more than a checklist:

Book Service Now

Questions? WhatsApp Entel directly via the website. No bots. No call centres. One person who has been through it.

VISIT SETTLEANZ.COM